

European Technology Hardware and Asian semiconductors

2Q26 postview – better fundamentals, but still a high bar ahead

With the SOXX still down >20% since its June/July peak, are semis interesting again? 2028 valuations look attractive, but 2027 whilst more palatable now, in our view, still appears full. We believe this cycle will last longer but expectations remain high and there are nearer-term debates to navigate

Fundamentals improved in 2Q, but expectations were high(er). Semis saw one of their best quarters in years in 2Q (SOXX up >90% vs market c14%). This set a high bar for earnings as we wrote in [2Q26 previews – Positive but increasingly reflected](#) (29 June 2026). Most companies beat consensus but failed to surpass investor expectations. Technical factors and wider AI dynamics have added to the pressure. Looking at our estimates post 2Q, most names have derated 5x+ on 2027E P/E as share prices declined but EPS moved up – we increased EPS for a number of companies by 10% post 2Q reporting.

Seeking a catalyst. Our first thoughts on 3Q would suggest the bar to beat expectations hasn't come down after 2Q – the only difference is valuations now look somewhat more reasonable. This could ultimately prove to be enough, but a more tangible catalyst would increase confidence. Demand clearly remains strong, emphasised by Nvidia earnings. However, we do not see clear reasons for narratives to improve materially in the short term. We will also need to navigate geopolitics (presidential summit at the end of September) as well as wider AI newsflow (potential IPOs, new model releases, ARR trajectories, enterprise AI monetisation, etc.).

Cautious nearer term, still positive long term. We see a number of debates set to continue that could hold back our coverage nearer term (see body of report), but we think many names look attractive, even here, in particular TSMC, SK hynix, Samsung, ASML and ASM (all OW). Improved visibility on the sustainability of strength into 2028 is likely needed for our coverage to rerate meaningfully, but these data points should start to come through in the coming 6+ months. We think there is still significant latent demand and that keeps us positive longer term.

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CONTENTS

Key questions and debates..... 3

Interesting charts..... 5

Key questions and debates

Our overall takeaway is that 2Q strengthened confidence in sector fundamentals but that investor expectations had already moved materially higher. Thus, the key question is increasingly shifting from whether AI demand is strong to whether it can accelerate enough to drive another round of estimate upgrades into 2027, in our view, as 2027 valuations currently look full (and as 2028 remains too far away).

What could drive another leg of outperformance?

We see limited scope for near-term earnings surprises following broadly positive 2Q results and estimate revisions. Therefore, the next leg higher likely requires either 1) AI revenue growth to accelerate again, 2) visibility into 2028 earnings to improve, or 3) geopolitical risks to diminish. Conversely, if earnings continue to rise broadly in line with expectations, valuation expansion may remain difficult.

Below we list a number of debates we have had with investors in the past month as well as our latest thoughts.

- How can AI surprise to the upside at this point?** We believe the market is starting to focus primarily on the risk of AI demand slowing rather than accelerating. Upside could come from three areas: (1) larger frontier model training requirements, (2) higher inference intensity as reasoning and agentic workloads increase, and (3) the emergence of new AI use cases that stimulate additional compute demand. If AI revenues accelerate, then concerns on hyperscaler capex and AI ROI could abate, which would remove a major drag for semis. Hyperscaler cloud revenue growth accelerated meaningfully in 2Q (see [here](#)) and further acceleration is likely needed. We continue to think we are very early on the AI adoption timeline. Frontier lab ARR expectations are therefore potentially also a key driver of semis in 4Q. Planned compute additions in 2027 appear set to exceed those in 2026, providing scope for further ARR acceleration, but there are clearly a number of moving parts. Datacentres in space remain a potential source of upside that does not appear to be reflected in investor expectations, albeit for understandable reasons given the execution and timing uncertainties (see [Bloomberg](#)).
- Memory multiples are attractive, but what is the catalyst?** We see no reason that the supply/demand tightness being seen in memory is going to improve any time before 2028 at the earliest, and even then it may only be a modest improvement. Thus, pricing should remain supportive through most of 2027, and the risk may now be skewed modestly to the upside. Memory is typically a leading indicator for the cycle, and misses on ASPs at 2Q compounded the view that pricing growth had peaked. We don't dispute that and with DRAM one of the few places we cut numbers post 2Q, expectations here don't seem as extreme. Typically, this would not be the time to engage, but post-cash P/Es (given significant cash returns ahead) are extremely low, even vs history, so it may not take much. Nvidia disclosed that its commitments have increased from \$119bn to \$279bn, primarily driven by memory, which should provide some comfort that memory pricing is sustainable into 2028 at least. The risks to memory include China expansion and/or further software/algorithmic improvements. On the former, whilst we expect China to accelerate its expansion, we do not see this freeing up meaningful bits and geopolitics should protect US DC demand. We see software and algorithmic improvements as necessary to achieve further AI scaling and, if successful, likely to stimulate incremental demand rather than reduce it. A rerating in memory could also support broader semiconductor valuations, particularly across semicap.
- Geopolitics.** The presidential summit between the US and China is set for late September, and headline risk tends to increase heading into these events. Given concerns around these

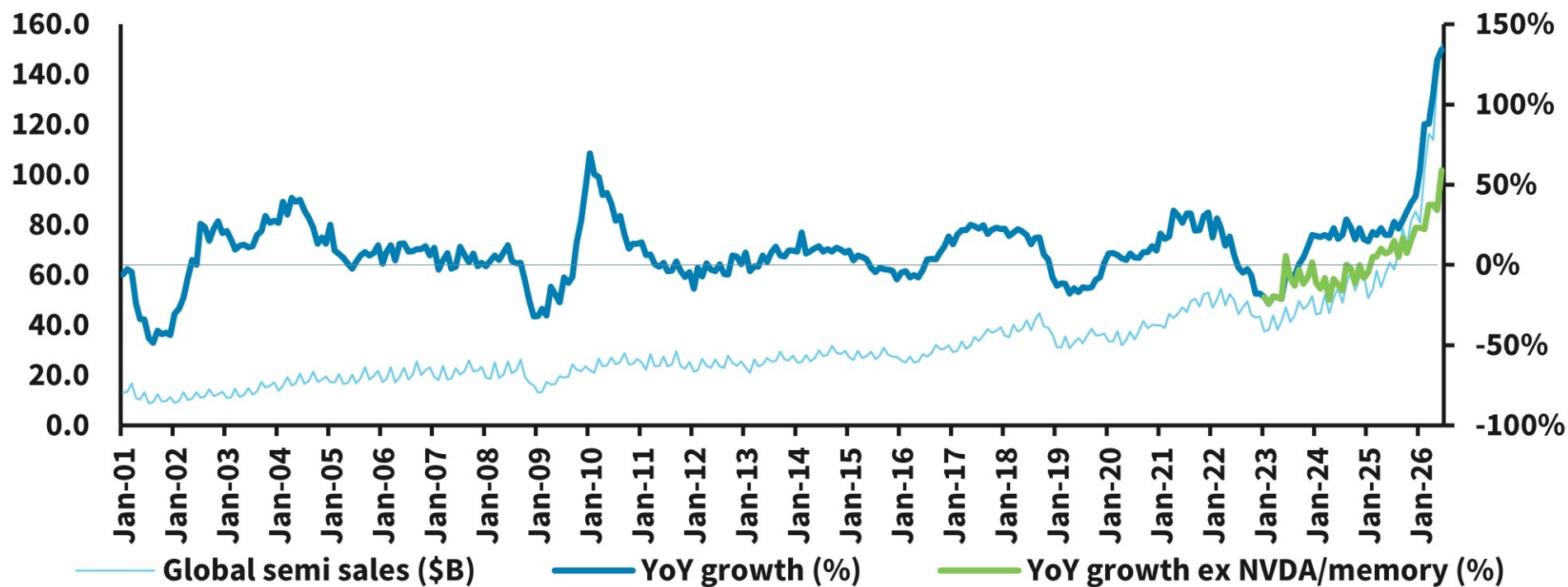
risks, clearing this event with no major changes to export controls, etc., would be a major positive. Tariff risk has also now resurfaced ([Politico](#), 27 August 2026), which is unhelpful.

- **Hyperscaler capex.** Concerns on how much hyperscalers are spending have continued to surface, compounded by debates on financing. Our colleagues addressed this in detail – see [Framework for Modeling AI Demand & Supply – Capex 'Peak' Likely in 2028](#) (11 March 2026). Our simple view is that hyperscalers wouldn't spend the capex if they weren't comfortable demand was there and whilst there can be nearer-term shifts, we remain bullish on how much demand will materialise. Supporting evidence, in our view, is the substantial backlogs across the ecosystem, the acceleration in hyperscaler cloud growth in 2Q, and improving profitability trends at frontier labs. Our colleagues now expect hyperscaler capex to peak beyond 2028 (see [here](#)).
- **Fundamentals vs expectations.** We continue to see improving fundamentals across the full semi supply chain as evidenced in 2Q. AI demand is insatiable and this is benefiting nearly all of our coverage whether directly or indirectly. In some areas, particularly analog, we continue to believe that AI demand is driving supply chain concerns, which is driving the upcycle so far rather than being demand-driven, which could create issues in early 2027, but inventories look reasonable for now. Thus, one of the key questions is no longer whether fundamentals are improving but whether they are improving fast enough to exceed expectations, which may prove difficult in the nearer term, in our view, following the positive revisions mostly seen post 2Q earnings.
- **Other AI debates.** We expect to see more new models released in the coming month. Whilst each will aim to show how it beats competitors on various benchmarks and more efficiently, what may be most interesting is if these new models can present new use cases that aren't currently considered. If so, this could help with monetisation debates. If not, then this could be a further headwind for semis in the near term.

Overall, whilst we remain constructive on sector fundamentals, we believe the burden of proof for further outperformance hasn't reduced following 2Q.

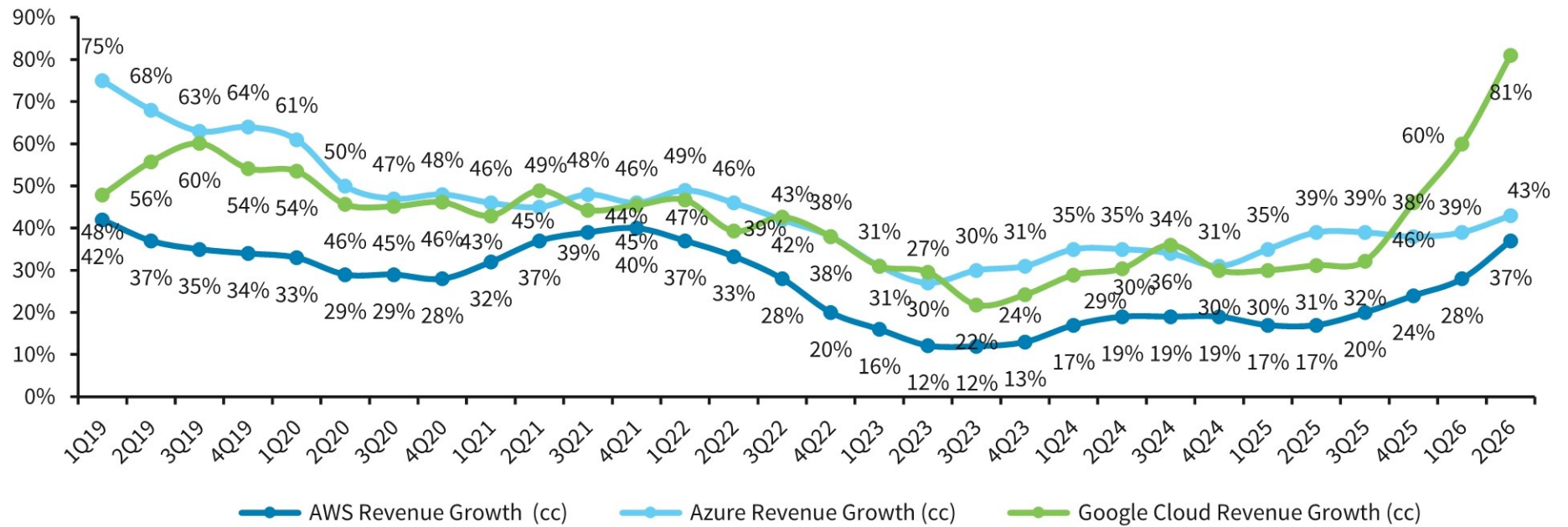
Interesting charts

FIGURE 1. Global semi sales and yoy growth



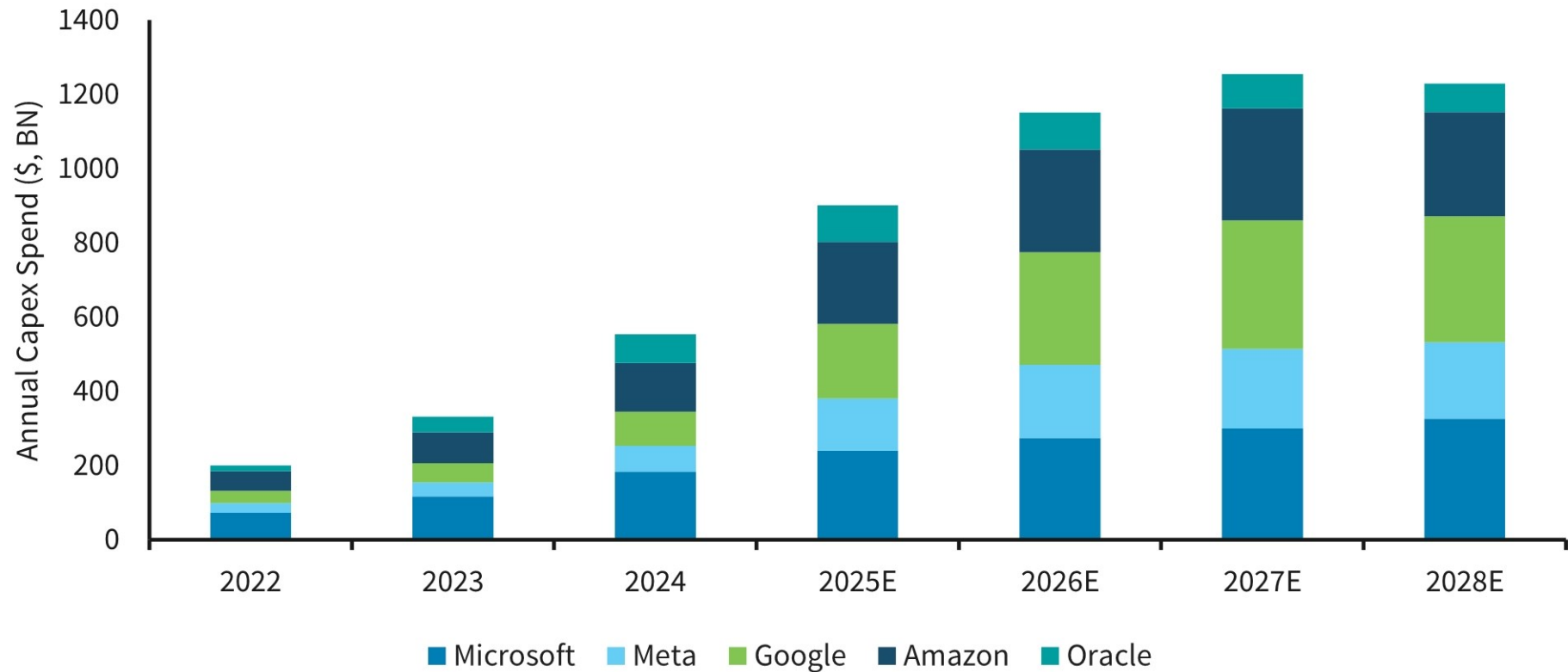
Source: Barclays Research, WSTS

FIGURE 2. Hyperscaler cloud growth



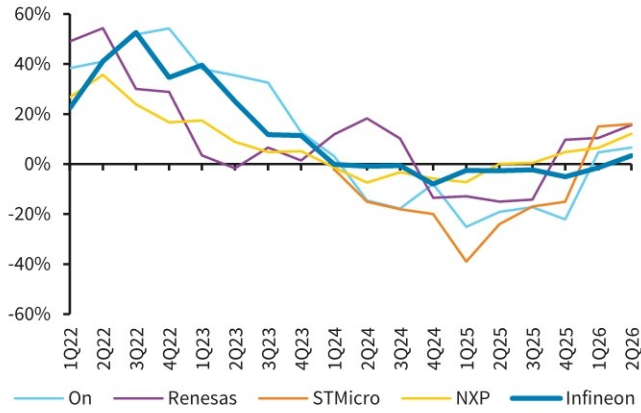
From CQ2 Public Cloud Update; Strong Hyperscaler Results Confirm Healthy AI Demand, 31 July 2026
 Source: Barclays Research, company data

FIGURE 3. Hyperscaler capex by calendar year in \$bn



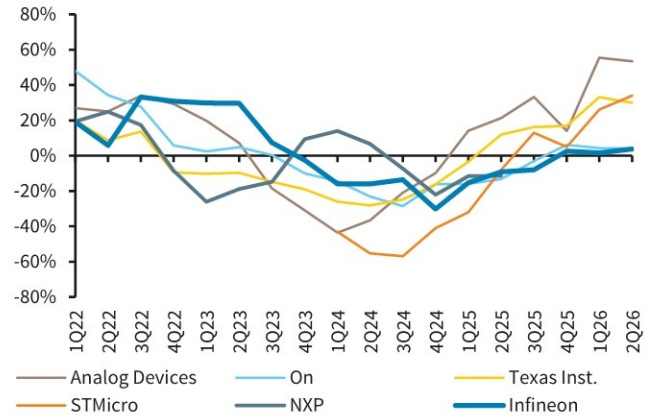
Source: Bloomberg consensus estimates

FIGURE 4. Auto semi sales growth by company (y/y)



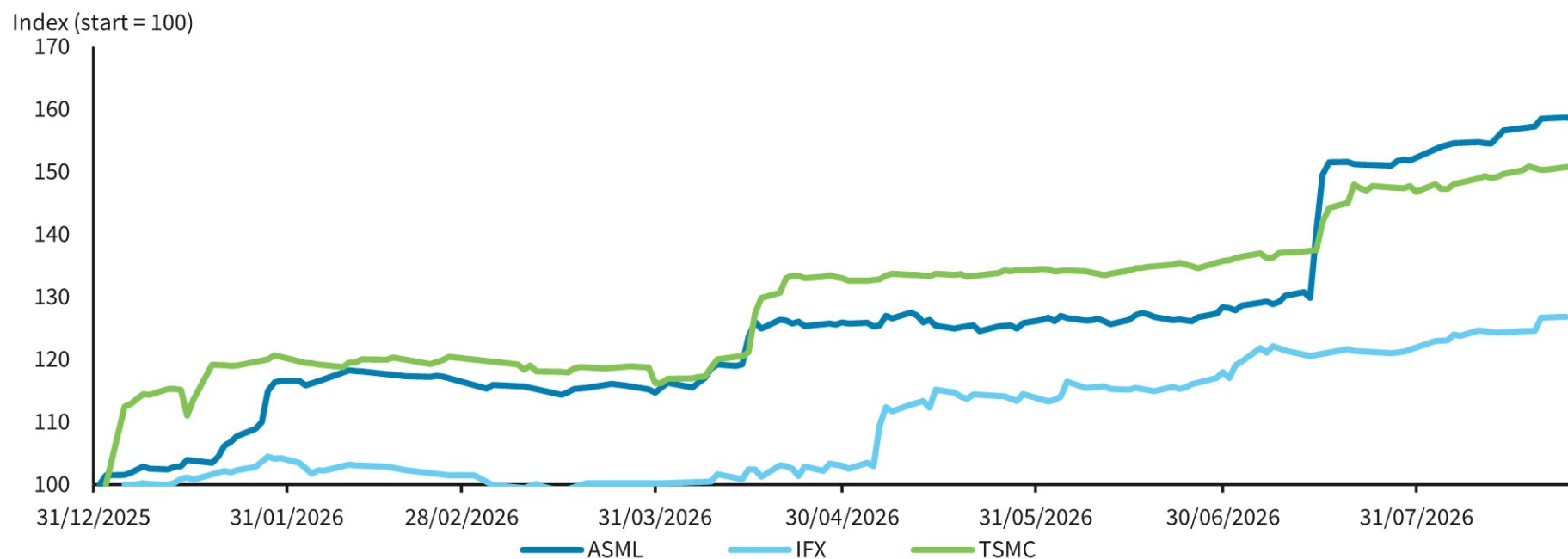
Calendar quarters
Source: Barclays Research, company data

FIGURE 5. Industrial sales growth by company (y/y)



Calendar quarters
Source: Barclays Research, company data

FIGURE 6. Consensus 2027 EPS revisions



Note: We label EPS on an index basis and show changes across the dates
Source: Barclays Research estimates, Bloomberg

FIGURE 7. Comp table

	Share Price	P/E (adj) (x)			EV/Sales (x)			EV/EBIT (x)			Dividend yield (%)		
Industry		2026E	2027E	2028E	2026E	2027E	2028E	2026E	2027E	2028E	2026E	2027E	2028E
Barclays Estimates													
Aixtron (EW, PT €42)	€37.0	50.0x	26.3x	26.2x	7.3x	5.2x	4.9x	38.3x	20.0x	19.2x	0.4%	0.4%	0.4%
ASML (OW, PT €2400)	€1486.4	38.4x	29.3x	21.8x	13.3x	10.8x	8.9x	33.3x	26.0x	20.0x	0.6%	0.6%	0.7%
ASMI (OW, PT €1200)	€827.4	35.8x	28.0x	25.1x	8.9x	7.0x	6.2x	27.4x	21.1x	19.2x	0.4%	0.5%	0.5%
Besi (EW, PT €250)	€195.0	42.1x	35.0x	27.0x	15.6x	13.7x	10.9x	35.9x	30.3x	23.7x	2.2%	2.5%	3.4%
STMicro (EW, PT €60)	€43.6	40.8x	20.1x	14.7x	3.2x	2.6x	2.3x	34.5x	17.0x	11.8x	0.7%	0.7%	0.7%
Infineon (OW, PT €90)	€57.3	32.0x	19.7x	15.3x	4.7x	3.8x	3.1x	24.3x	14.9x	11.3x	0.6%	0.6%	0.6%
ams-OSRAM (EW, PT CHF20)	CHF18.2	N/A	N/A	15.7x	1.2x	1.2x	1.1x	17.3x	15.7x	11.3x	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%

	Share Price	P/E (adj) (x)			EV/Sales (x)			EV/EBIT (x)			Dividend yield (%)		
Soitec (EW, PT €110)	€110.5	N/A	81.9x	40.7x	6.7x	5.4x	4.5x	N/A	60.0x	33.1x	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Nordic (EW, PT NOK180)	NOK169.8	45.4x	31.1x	23.6x	3.9x	3.3x	2.7x	32.7x	22.3x	16.5x	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Samsung (OW, PT \$8300)	\$4702	6.5x	4.7x	4.2x	2.0x	1.3x	1.0x	3.9x	2.4x	1.8x	0.8%	0.7%	0.8%
SK Hynix (OW, PT \$300)	\$161	6.3x	3.9x	3.3x	4.8x	2.9x	2.6x	6.3x	3.6x	3.3x	5.1%	8.0%	9.1%
TSMC (OW, PT \$650)	\$428.6	25.1x	20.0x	17.2x	12.0x	8.9x	7.1x	20.4x	15.5x	13.0x	0.9%	0.9%	1.2%
Ericsson (UW, PT SEK80)	SEK96.2	20.1x	15.4x	15.0x	1.7x	1.6x	1.5x	11.6x	12.3x	11.7x	3.1%	3.1%	3.1%
Nokia (UW, PT €8)	€9.0	26.5x	22.4x	19.5x	2.4x	2.2x	2.0x	21.1x	16.8x	14.0x	1.8%	2.0%	2.2%
Bloomberg Estimates													
Semicap Equipment - Front End													
Aixtron	€37.0	49.6x	27.5x	22.4x	6.5x	4.7x	4.1x	34.5x	18.6x	14.8x	0.5%	0.7%	0.9%
ASMI	€827.4	35.7x	27.6x	22.9x	9.6x	7.4x	6.4x	29.1x	21.9x	18.1x	0.5%	0.6%	0.7%
ASML	€1486.4	39.3x	28.6x	22.4x	13.1x	10.3x	8.5x	32.6x	23.5x	18.5x	0.6%	0.8%	0.9%
Soitec	€110.5	1347.6x	42.2x	22.0x	5.7x	4.5x	3.5x	134.9x	31.7x	16.9x	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Applied Materials	\$476.5	36.9x	25.8x	20.6x	10.9x	8.0x	6.7x	33.2x	22.3x	17.7x	0.4%	0.4%	0.5%
KLA	\$183.5	33.5x	27.2x	23.8x	13.2x	11.0x	9.9x	28.4x	23.2x	20.9x	0.5%	0.6%	0.6%
Lam Research	\$315.9	33.9x	27.5x	23.1x	11.5x	9.8x	8.5x	29.2x	23.9x	20.3x	0.4%	0.4%	0.5%
Tokyo Electron	¥56000	33.6x	24.5x	19.6x	7.7x	6.2x	5.3x	25.9x	19.0x	15.4x	1.5%	2.0%	2.5%
<i>Median</i>	-	36.3x	27.5x	22.4x	10.2x	7.7x	6.5x	30.9x	22.8x	17.9x	0.5%	0.6%	0.7%
Semicap Equipment - Back End													
Besi	€195.0	44.5x	29.7x	22.7x	15.6x	11.6x	9.2x	37.0x	25.0x	18.6x	1.8%	2.7%	3.5%
ASM PT	HKD165.7	39.5x	27.2x	21.0x	3.6x	3.0x	2.6x	27.9x	20.4x	15.4x	1.3%	1.8%	2.4%
Kulicke & Soffa	\$85.7	22.2x	14.5x	16.0x	3.5x	2.6x	2.7x	16.6x	10.3x	11.0x	1.0%	1.0%	1.0%
SUSS Microtec	€72.5	39.7x	18.9x	15.2x	2.8x	2.1x	1.9x	27.4x	13.1x	10.5x	0.3%	0.5%	0.9%
<i>Median</i>	-	39.6x	23.1x	18.5x	3.5x	2.8x	2.7x	27.7x	16.8x	13.2x	1.1%	1.4%	1.7%
Semiconductor - IDM													
ams-OSRAM	€18.2	N/A	N/A	15.7x	1.4x	1.4x	1.3x	20.0x	17.2x	13.5x	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Infineon	€57.3	33.0x	20.4x	15.2x	5.0x	4.1x	3.6x	26.0x	16.8x	12.4x	0.6%	0.8%	0.8%
STMicro	€43.6	37.5x	19.3x	13.8x	3.1x	2.6x	2.3x	33.8x	15.8x	10.7x	0.7%	0.7%	0.8%
Analog Devices	\$375.2	29.1x	22.4x	19.1x	12.5x	10.2x	9.5x	25.2x	19.8x	17.5x	1.1%	1.2%	1.3%
Microchip	\$75.1	20.6x	16.4x	14.2x	7.4x	6.4x	5.8x	19.5x	15.7x	13.9x	2.5%	2.5%	2.9%

	Share Price	P/E (adj) (x)			EV/Sales (x)			EV/EBIT (x)			Dividend yield (%)		
NXP	\$228.1	15.1x	12.5x	10.7x	4.6x	4.1x	3.8x	12.9x	11.0x	9.8x	1.9%	2.0%	2.2%
On Semi	\$74.4	23.1x	16.4x	12.6x	4.4x	3.9x	3.5x	20.2x	14.5x	11.4x	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Renesas	¥3380	13.6x	11.8x	10.3x	4.4x	4.0x	3.6x	20.8x	17.6x	15.7x	0.8%	1.0%	1.2%
Rohm	¥4830	44.3x	30.6x	23.8x	3.5x	3.3x	3.1x	40.6x	26.4x	19.8x	1.0%	1.1%	1.1%
Texas Instruments	\$267.1	32.9x	26.0x	20.2x	11.5x	9.9x	8.7x	27.9x	22.0x	17.9x	2.2%	2.2%	2.3%
<i>Median</i>	-	29.1x	19.3x	14.7x	4.5x	4.1x	3.6x	23.0x	17.0x	13.7x	0.9%	1.1%	1.1%
Semiconductor - Fabless													
Nordic Semiconductor	NOK169.8	64.1x	37.0x	25.7x	4.1x	3.5x	3.0x	46.3x	26.8x	17.9x	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
AMD	\$473.7	62.5x	31.0x	21.5x	15.0x	8.8x	6.4x	53.6x	27.0x	18.5x	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Broadcom	\$369.6	31.8x	19.2x	14.3x	17.0x	10.4x	7.7x	25.6x	16.0x	12.1x	0.8%	0.9%	1.2%
Marvell	\$244.6	60.3x	38.6x	24.9x	18.6x	12.7x	8.8x	51.1x	33.3x	21.5x	0.1%	0.1%	0.1%
NVIDIA	\$229.8	25.0x	15.5x	11.8x	13.5x	8.5x	6.7x	20.6x	13.0x	10.1x	0.3%	0.4%	0.7%
<i>Median</i>	-	60.3x	31.0x	21.5x	15.0x	8.8x	6.7x	46.3x	26.8x	17.9x	0.1%	0.1%	0.1%
Semiconductor - Foundry													
TSMC	\$428.6	25.4x	19.4x	15.8x	12.5x	9.3x	7.4x	21.4x	15.9x	12.7x	1.0%	1.2%	1.4%
Intel	\$90.8	59.8x	43.9x	30.0x	8.1x	7.0x	6.1x	55.4x	37.5x	26.5x	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
GlobalFoundries	\$46.2	24.0x	17.8x	13.1x	3.2x	2.9x	2.5x	19.1x	14.2x	10.1x	0.3%	0.6%	0.9%
UMC	TWD118.5	16.8x	16.3x	13.5x	5.0x	4.0x	3.5x	21.6x	14.1x	11.4x	3.3%	4.0%	4.8%
Hua Hong	HKD122.8	136.2x	89.5x	69.3x	12.3x	9.8x	8.5x	449.5x	140.4x	88.7x	0.0%	0.0%	0.1%
Tower Semiconductor	\$220.5	57.0x	33.8x	23.4x	11.9x	8.3x	6.9x	54.4x	26.2x	16.8x	N/A	N/A	N/A
<i>Median</i>	-	41.2x	26.6x	19.6x	10.0x	7.7x	6.5x	38.0x	21.1x	14.8x	0.3%	0.6%	0.9%
Semiconductor - Memory													
Samsung	\$4702	5.4x	3.7x	3.4x	1.9x	1.4x	1.3x	3.5x	2.4x	2.3x	3.2%	3.4%	4.1%
SK Hynix	KRW1.74m	5.0x	3.8x	3.4x	3.4x	2.2x	1.9x	4.4x	2.8x	2.6x	0.7%	1.6%	1.9%
Micron	\$914.8	12.6x	6.0x	5.4x	7.8x	4.1x	3.6x	10.3x	4.9x	4.6x	0.1%	0.2%	0.2%
WDC	\$449.9	22.7x	14.2x	10.5x	8.1x	6.0x	5.0x	16.7x	10.2x	7.7x	0.1%	0.1%	0.2%
Nanya Technology	TWD541.0	8.4x	5.3x	4.6x	4.7x	3.0x	2.5x	6.3x	3.9x	3.6x	3.6%	5.6%	6.9%
<i>Median</i>	-	8.4x	5.3x	4.6x	4.7x	3.0x	2.5x	6.3x	3.9x	3.6x	0.7%	1.6%	1.9%
Telecom Equipment													
Ericsson	SEK96.2	15.1x	13.8x	12.5x	1.2x	1.2x	1.2x	9.5x	8.9x	8.6x	3.2%	3.4%	3.5%

	Share Price	P/E (adj) (x)			EV/Sales (x)			EV/EBIT (x)			Dividend yield (%)		
Nokia	€9.0	26.2x	21.7x	18.8x	2.4x	2.2x	2.1x	21.7x	17.1x	14.0x	1.7%	1.8%	2.0%
<i>Median</i>	-	20.6x	17.8x	15.7x	1.8x	1.7x	1.6x	15.6x	13.0x	11.3x	2.5%	2.6%	2.7%

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Source: Barclays Research estimates, Bloomberg. Stock prices as of 27/08/2026

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Materially Mentioned Stocks (Ticker, Date, Price)

ASM International N.V. (ASMI.AS, 27-Aug-2026, EUR 827.40), Overweight/Neutral, J

ASML Holding NV (ASML.AS, 27-Aug-2026, EUR 1486.40), Overweight/Neutral, CD/CE/FA/J

Micron Technology, Inc. (MU, 26-Aug-2026, USD 938.40), Overweight/Neutral, CD/CE/FA/J/K/M/N

SK Hynix Inc.. Adr (SKHY, 26-Aug-2026, USD 158.02), Overweight/Neutral, CD/CE/J

Samsung Electronics Co Ltd (0593xq.L, 27-Aug-2026, USD 4702.00), Overweight/Neutral, CD/J/K/M/N

Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Company (TSM, 26-Aug-2026, USD 417.69), Overweight/Neutral, CD/CE/J/K/M

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ASML Holding NV (ASML.AS)	BE Semiconductor Industries NV (BESI.AS)	Ericsson (ERICb.ST)
Infineon Technologies AG (IFXGn.DE)	Nokia (NOKIA.HE)	Nordic Semiconductor ASA (NOD.OL)

Samsung Electronics Co Ltd (0593xq.L)	SK Hynix Inc.. ADR (SKHY)	Soitec (SOIT.PA)
STMicroelectronics NV (STM.PA)	Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Company (TSM)	

U.S. Semiconductors & Semiconductor Capital Equipment

Advanced Micro Devices (AMD)	Allegro Microsystems (ALGM)	Analog Devices (ADI)
Applied Materials Inc. (AMAT)	Arm Holdings plc (ARM)	Astera Labs, Inc. (ALAB)
Broadcom Inc. (AVGO)	Camtek (CAMT)	Cerebras Systems Inc. (CBRS)
Cirrus Logic Inc. (CRUS)	Coherent Corp. (COHR)	Credo Technology Group (CRDO)
Intel Corp. (INTC)	KLA Corporation (KLAC)	Lam Research Corporation (LRCX)
Lumentum Holdings Inc. (LITE)	MACOM Technology Solutions Holdings, Inc. (MTSI)	Marvell Technology Group, Ltd. (MRVL)
Microchip Technology (MCHP)	Micron Technology, Inc. (MU)	Nova Limited (NVMl)
NVIDIA Corp. (NVDA)	NXP Semiconductors NV (NXPI)	ON Semiconductor (ON)
Penguin Solutions (PENG)	Qorvo Inc. (QRVO)	QUALCOMM, Inc. (QCOM)
Sandisk Corporation (SNDK)	Seagate Technology plc (STX)	Silicon Laboratories, Inc. (SLAB)
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U.S. Semiconductors & Semiconductor Capital Equipment

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